

Chapter 4

WHY DO WE LEARN HISTORY?

Learning Outcomes

After studying this chapter the students will be able to:

1. Differentiate between solar and lunar calendars.
2. Use solar and lunar calendars to differentiate intervals of time.
3. Differentiate between decades, centuries and millennia.

WHY DO WE LEARN HISTORY?

History is the study of how people lived in the past. Students have often asked, “Why do we have to learn about the people who lived in the past?”, “Why do we have to learn history?”

Why do you think it is important to study history?

We study history to learn how people lived in the past. We learn about the past because it helps us to understand our world today. History tells us how our way of life, that is, the language we speak, the way we dress, our laws and form of government began. It tells us how what happened in the past affects us today. In studying the history of other countries we learn why people in other countries have a different way of life from ours and how their past affects them today.

We also study history so as to make the world a better place for the people who live in it today and who will live in it in the future. We do this by trying to learn lessons from the successes and failure of the past.

1800s



Stone age

Mughal period

Today

Fig 4.1 The change in transportation and ways of dressing over time

Activity

Make a list of the things you would put in a box and bury so that people living in the future would know how you lived today. Near each item on the list write what people who found the box many years later would learn about how people lived today from that item?

Counting Time

In studying history, it is very important to know when things happened because the world has existed for a very long time. To be able to say when something happened we need to have a date from where to begin, a date we can call Year One.

Different people use different dates for their Year One. Often this date is an important date in their religion.

Types of Calendars

The sun and moon are means to count the passage of time. Time is counted as days, weeks, months and years. There are a number of calendars being used in the world today that tell us the day, week, month and year. The two most common are the solar calendar and the lunar calendar.

The Solar Calendar

Many countries use the solar calendar. The solar calendar is based on the time the Earth takes to travel around the sun. The Earth takes about $365 \frac{1}{4}$ days to revolve around the sun. Therefore, one solar year is equal to $365 \frac{1}{4}$ days. By adding the $\frac{1}{4}$ day, every four years an additional day is obtained. Therefore, every fourth year has 366 days and the year is called a leap year. The solar calendar has twelve months. The months are of 30 or 31 days, except February that is of 28 days and of 29 days in the leap year.

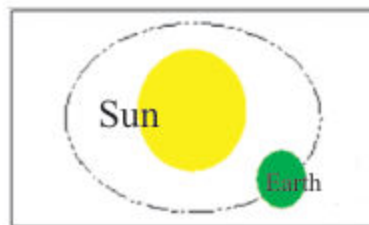


Fig 4.2 The Earth moving around the Sun

In this calendar, Year One is the year when Jesus Christ was born. After writing the year, the letters AD which stand for Anno Domini are written. Anno Domini means “In the year of our Lord” which means years after the birth of Jesus Christ. We know that Sir Syed Ahmed Khan was born in 1817AD this means one thousand eight hundred and seventeen years after the birth of Jesus Christ.

Many things happened before Jesus Christ was born. The time before Jesus Christ was born is shown by writing the letters BC after the year. BC stands for “Before Christ”. For years before Jesus Christ we count back from Year One. For example, Asoka was born in 269 BC and lived for 37 years he died in 232 BC. On the other hand Shirin was born in 40 AD and lived for 60 years she died in 100 AD.

Asoka Born 269 B.C.	Asoka Died 232 B.C.	Christian Year One	Shirin Born 40 A.D.	Shirin Died 100 A.D.

Fig 4.3 A timeline showing Year One in the Solar Calendar

Activity

1. Use the timeline to answer the question given below?



- Saleem was born in 50 AD and lived for 40 years. He died in _____
- Mariam was born in 90 BC and lived for 60 years. She died in _____
- Sharukh was born in 105 BC and died in 40 BC. He lived for _____ years.
- Angela died in 95 AD at the age of 72. She was born in _____

Activity

What are the months of the solar year? Which was the last leap year? When will the next leap Year be?

The Lunar Calendar

The Lunar calendar is based on the time the moon takes to go around the Earth. The moon takes 29 or 30 days to go around the Earth, therefore, each lunar month is either 29 or 30 days long. Like the solar calendar, the lunar calendar also has twelve months. The solar calendar is, therefore, 11 days longer than the lunar calendar. The lunar calendar begins from the Hijrah or the migration of Prophet Muhammad (*Sall Allah-o-Alaihi-Wasallam*) from Makkah to Madina. All the events that followed are described in relation to the time after the Hijrah. For example, Prophet Muhammad (*Sall Allah-o-Alaihi-Wasallam*) died eleven years after the Hijrah. Hence, it is recorded as 11 AH. The letters AH stands for After Hijrah.

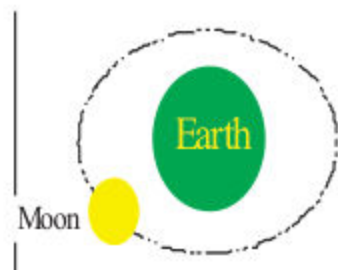


Fig. 4.4 The moon rotating around the Earth

Activity

List the twelve months of the Lunar calendar.

Look at today's newspaper. Find out the date according to both the Solar and Lunar Calendars.

Do you know?

- A period of ten years (10) is called a decade.
- A period of one hundred years (100) is called a century.
- A period of one thousand years (1000) is called a millennia.

SUMMARY

In this chapter we have learnt the importance of studying history. We have also learnt how the sun and the moon is used to count the passage of time and how to use the two calendars the solar calendar and the lunar calendar - to differentiate intervals of time.

EXERCISE

A. Multiple choice questions

1. For every question, three answers are given; tick the correct one.

- i. How many days does a leap year have?
a) 360 b) 365 c) 366

- ii. How many days does February have in a leap year?
a) 27 b) 28 c) 29

- iii. How many years are there in a decade?
a) 10 b) 100 c) 1000

- iv. How many years are there in a century?
a) 10 b) 100 c) 1000

- v. What does a millennium mean?
a) 10 years b) 100 years c) 1000 years

B. Answer the following questions

1. Why do we learn history?
2. What do BC, AD and AH stand for?
3. Name the twelve months in the solar or Christian and lunar or Islamic calendar.
4. How many days are there in a week, a month, a year?
5. How many years are there in a decade, century and millennium?
6. Compare (similarities and differences) the solar and lunar calendars.

C. Complete the table

Make a table to show the twelve months of the solar and lunar calendars.

Months of the Solar Calendar		Months of the Lunar Calendar	
1		1	
2		2	
3		3	
4		4	
5		5	
6		6	
7		7	
8		8	
9		9	
10		10	
11		11	
12		12	

D. Practical work

Make a time line of your own life showing important events on it. Draw or paste photographs of the events.

E. Extension activity

Find out your date of birth on the Solar and Lunar calendars.